recognizes that this is because, ‘in your case, let me say that it has been a weakness—a weakness of the worst type’. It is the weakness of the father’s utter helplessness, of a father driven to despair as he awaits the inevitable—the hanging to death of his eldest son. Bhagat Singh recognizes this only too well. This is why he tells his father, ‘I know you are as sincere a patriot as one can be.’ [12]

From this it is clear that Bhagat Singh’s unabated anger at his father is motivated by the loss of face with his condemned comrades. They had all determinedly decided to wilfully face the gallows, kissing the noose as they proceeded to joyously place it around their necks. For them there were no half measures. What they wanted was to make the ultimate sacrifice. It is righteous anger that Bhagat Singh now felt for his father, an indignation at his father’s attempt to dissuade him from his long-planned course of action—a meeting with death. This is why all three condemned prisoners—Bhagat Singh, Rajguru and Sukhdev—offered no defence. They entered no plea. This is why Bhagat Singh berated his father for a ‘weakness of the worst type’ as this was a weakness of a father unable to countenance with equanimity his son’s determination to extinguish himself.

But that is not to say that his father had no formative influence on him. To obscure or negate his family’s critical role in his revolutionary upbringing is to focus on the part and to miss the whole. The decisive influence on his later life may have lain elsewhere. It may have been the case, as Moffat describes, that Bhagat Singh staked out a claim to work ‘outside a trajectory determined by bloodlines and instead in the context of twentieth-century revolutionary politics more generally’. [13] It may be that he had ‘a peculiarly *para-national* sensibility’, grounded in a relationship with nationalism but not circumscribed by it, given how he and his associates had founded the student, Naujawan Bharat Sabha. [14]

Yet, it is clear that his family background was such that he could not have been blissfully unaware of it. Tied to this is the fact that the agrarian revolts of 1907, in which Bhagat Singh’s uncle Ajit Singh was involved, had a distinctly ‘Punjabi’ provenance in the subsequent struggle for Indian Independence, which was eventually realized in 1947. Like many others, it